

The Winter Gate Library

Licensed classic · labyrinth edition

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Door That Breathed Frost

Noor and Eli were twins who disagreed about most things except this: the Labyrinth Library was home.

On the first snow-night of Reader's Month, they found a door they had never seen, set between shelves of travel journals and winter folktales. Frost curled from its keyhole like a sleeping cat's breath.

The brass plate read:

WINTER GATE LIBRARY Enter with warm voice.

Eli touched the handle. "Warm voice?"

Noor hummed a lullaby their grandmother used. The door unlocked with a sound like cracking lake ice.

Beyond lay a wing glazed in blue light. Shelves held books wrapped in thin frost. Titles were visible only as shadows beneath ice.

"No silent reading here," a sign said.

Eli whispered, "Challenge accepted."

Nothing happened.

Noor read the sign aloud, clearly. Frost on the nearest book thinned, revealing letters:

The First Tale of the Long Thaw.

"Read aloud," Noor said.

Eli groaned. "I knew it."

Noor pulled a stool from the wall — the wing seemed to offer furniture when needed — and sat beside him. "We trade paragraphs. You read the exciting parts. I read the slow parts."

"That is literally every book ever," Eli said.

"Then we are qualified."

Frost glittered on the ceiling like a map of unread words. Their breath made small clouds. Somewhere distant, a bell chimed once, not urgent, just welcoming.

Eli opened the book. His first paragraph came out flat. Noor shook her head. "Warmer."

He tried again, adding the tiny smile he used when he actually cared. Ice on the title page thinned.

"Better," the wing seemed to sigh.

They read until their toes stopped aching from cold, then Vale appeared with thick socks and a thermos of spiced cider that tasted like patience.

The first tale introduced characters they would meet again — a ferry captain who spoke in questions, a baker who measured flour by kindness, a child who collected frozen words in jars. Eli voiced the captain with too much drama. Noor voiced the baker with calm. Ice melted in stripes.

"Trade voices next chapter," Noor suggested.

Eli agreed, which surprised them both.

Between paragraphs they stamped their feet to keep warm. The wing responded by lowering a heat vent that smelled like old paper and orange peel.

Vale watched from the shadows, not judging, only noting which sentences made frost retreat fastest. Honest ones. Slow ones. Ones read twice without shame.

When they closed the book for the night, the cover held a faint handprint each — proof of warmth left behind.

Chapter 2 — Books That Stayed Cold

They opened the first book together, trading paragraphs.

Where Noor's voice was steady, ice melted in clean lines. Where Eli's voice stumbled, ice held on, patient but firm.

They learned quickly: this wing did not punish mistakes. It waited for persistence.

A librarian appeared — tall, wrapped in a cloak of woven page scraps, face kind and severe.

"I am Keeper Vale," they said. "Winter Gate preserves stories that freeze when unheard."

"Why?" Eli asked.

"Because some truths are shy," Vale said. "Cold keeps them from being rushed."

Noor nodded. "We can be slow."

Vale handed them wool fingerless gloves and a rule card:

1. Read aloud. 2. Share the hard pages. 3. Never mock a thawing sentence.

Vale walked them through the wing's aisles, pointing out features no map showed: the Listening Alcove where

echoes softened, the Repair Nook with tools for torn pages, the Quiet Pond — a bowl of frozen water that reflected not faces but feelings.

"If you lie to the pond," Vale said, "it stays frozen."

Eli tested that immediately. "I love homework more than comics."

The pond stayed ice.

Noor snorted. Eli tried again. "I am nervous about reading aloud."

The pond shimmered.

"Honesty is heat," Vale said.

They practiced on small books first — single poems, recipe cards, letters between fictional friends. Each success melted a little more frost from the shelves.

By closing time, their gloves were damp with thaw and their voices were tired in the good way.

"Return tomorrow," Vale said. "Winter Gate does not rush, but it does notice who returns."

On the walk back through the main library, Eli complained his throat hurt. Noor handed him honey sticks from her bag. He complained less.

They passed the Allen Girls team shelving returns. Maya waved. Eli waved back, suddenly shy about his new warm-voice mission.

"New wing?" Maya asked.

"Winter Gate," Noor said. "You have to read aloud."

Maya grinned. "Natalia would love it."

"We will bring her," Eli said, before he could overthink.

That night they practiced on their bedroom bookshelf — fairy tales, comics, the manual for a board game nobody played anymore. Their grandmother listened from the hall, smiling at the voices that used to argue over who went first.

"Same kids," she whispered. "Warmer delivery."

Snow tapped the window. The labyrinth, somewhere beneath the town, kept its cold kind patience.

Chapter 3 — The Tale of the Long Thaw

The first book told of a village where words froze each winter until children read them back to life.

Noor read the village scenes. Eli read the storm scenes. When they reached a page about two siblings arguing, they both went quiet.

"Keep going," Vale said from the aisle.

Eli read the argument aloud, embarrassed because it sounded like their own fights about blankets, chores, and who got the better pencil.

As he read, frost on the margins melted into tiny rivers that sparkled under dome light.

Noor squeezed his hand once.

Not agreement. Not apology. Just stay.

The page turned itself when they finished, as if grateful.

They kept reading through the village tale — harvest scenes, storm scenes, reconciliation scenes. Noor handled the sentences about mothers and grandmothers. Eli handled the sentences about dogs and runaway sleds.

When the final chapter arrived, the book was almost clear of ice. Only the last line remained frosted:

Stay when the story gets honest.

They read it together, voices overlapping on purpose.

The frost vanished. The book warmed and left a scent like cedar and snowmelt.

Vale appeared with a stamp for their rule card: FIRST THAW COMPLETE.

Eli held it up. "We are officially warm-voice certified."

"Noor did half the work," he added quickly.

Noor bumped his shoulder. "Team thaw."

The wing brightened one shade, as if pleased with its new readers.

They brought Maya, Natalia, and SPARK on Thursday. Maya read a storm scene so well the ice crackled in rhythm. Natalia read a village scene and made the wing feel like home.

SPARK measured voice warmth with a silly meter shaped like a thermometer. "Eli: 87 percent cozy. Noor: 92 percent steady. Recommend combined reading for maximum thaw."

The Allen Girls team added a note to the rule card: Teams may borrow each other's courage.

Vale stamped it official.

Afterward they shared cider in the Listening Alcove. Maya declared Winter Gate "the feelings wing but in a cool way." Natalia asked to return every week. Eli pretended not to care, but booked Tuesdays on the spot.

Chapter 4 — The Frozen Apology

The second book contained only one sentence, repeated on every page beneath ice:

I am sorry I did not believe you.

Noor's throat tightened. "This one is hard."

Eli looked at the floor. "Maybe for me."

He read the sentence once. Ice cracked. Twice. Ice spidered. Third time, voice shaking: "I am sorry I did not believe you."

The ice shattered cleanly. The sentence changed:

I am learning to believe you now.

Vale placed a hand on Eli's shoulder. "Return tasks in Winter Gate are emotional, not decorative."

Noor read next, softer: "I am learning to believe you now."

The book closed and warmed in their palms.

They sat in silence for a minute, not awkward silence, the kind that follows hard truth spoken well.

Vale brought a third book, thinner, titled Questions I Was Afraid to Ask Aloud. Noor read half. Eli read half. Ice melted in patterns like lace.

A parent reader peeked in from the main library, curious. Vale invited them to listen but not to rescue. "Witness only," they said.

The parent stayed, eyes wet, and whispered thank you when Eli stumbled through a sentence about fear and kept going anyway.

Afterward, Eli said, "That was worse than the apology book."

"And you did it," Noor said.

He nodded. "Do not tell anyone I said that."

"I will tell everyone you kept reading," Noor replied.

He did not argue.

The next book held letters between sisters separated by a long winter. Noor read the older sister. Eli read the younger. Halfway through, they switched without planning — each voice fitting better in the other's role.

Vale called that advanced thawing. "Empathy swap," they said. "Rare at your age. Common here."

A visiting teacher asked if the wing could host a class. Vale looked at the twins. They nodded.

They co-hosted the first school visit — twenty students, nervous and giggling. Eli opened with a joke. Noor closed with breathing. Every child left with a rule card and one thawed poem.

"Human radiators, upgraded," Eli said on the walk home.

"Co-keepers in training," Noor replied.

Chapter 5 — The Choir of Cold Spines

In the choral aisle, books hummed at low frequency, frozen chords waiting for voices.

Noor and Eli practiced alternating lines until their timing matched.

Eli had rhythm when he stopped rushing. Noor had melody when she stopped overthinking.

Together they unlocked a shelf of winter lullabies from places readers rarely visited: mountain posts, ferry stations, lighthouse cots.

Keeper Vale recorded their voices in a frost cylinder "not for fame," they said, "for heating future pages."

Eli joked, "We are human radiators now."

Noor smiled. "Useful ones."

They practiced the choral aisle every afternoon for a week. Eli learned to wait half a beat before entering. Noor learned to breathe before high notes.

Other readers joined — a trio of cousins, a grandfather with a shaking voice, a girl who only whispered until the third day when she surprised everyone with volume.

Vale mixed their voices into the frost cylinder: not perfect studio sound, but real sound — breath, stumble, recovery.

"When future pages thaw," Vale said, "they will hear that effort is allowed."

Eli made a joke about being famous ghosts. Noor made him read the joke aloud so the wing could warm it.

By Friday, the choral aisle hummed even when empty, a low friendly chord that greeted newcomers.

"Winter Gate remembers voices," Vale said. "Especially the ones that return."

They started a logbook — not for grades, for weather. Monday: light thaw. Tuesday: choral breakthrough. Wednesday: Eli rushed, ice held. Thursday: repair reading, warmth returned.

Noor drew small suns next to good days. Eli drew clouds with faces next to hard days. Together the logbook became a map of learning, not perfection.

Maya visited and added glitter stars for "funniest recovery." SPARK added a column for decibel kindness. Natalia added a column for persistence minutes.

Vale read the logbook each night and adjusted which books they offered next — harder for confident days, gentler after fights or failed tests at school.

"You are not just thawing pages," Vale told them. "You are learning how you work."

Eli wrote that on the inside cover. Noor underlined it twice.

Chapter 6 — The Boy in the Ice Map

A map book held a frozen scene: a boy trapped in a blue square, mouth open mid-call.

Noor read the legend aloud. The boy could move only when someone answered his question.

The question appeared:

Do you see me when I am quiet?

Eli answered, "Yes."

The boy stepped out of the map and bowed. He was not real-real, Vale explained, but a memory of every quiet child passed over in noisy rooms.

He faded after thanking them, leaving a token: a blue marble that warmed when held.

Noor kept it in her pocket for hard days.

The map book had twelve frozen scenes. They thawed them one at a time — a ferry in fog, a classroom after recess, a kitchen table with two cups cooling.

Each scene asked a quiet question. Each answer had to be spoken, not guessed.

Eli answered most. Noor answered the ones that needed steadiness instead of speed.

On the final page, the boy from the blue square returned, not trapped this time, but walking beside them in illustration only.

"Thank you for answering when I was quiet," the caption read.

Vale recorded the twins' names in the map margin — not as heroes, as witnesses.

"That is higher praise here," Vale said.

Eli tucked the marble deeper in Noor's pocket. "In case you forget."

"I won't," she said. "But I like the backup."

Chapter 7 — The Argument That Froze the Wing

Noor and Eli fought on Thursday.

It was ordinary twin fighting — tone, teasing, too much homework, not enough sleep — but in Winter Gate, ordinary fights had weather.

Frost raced up shelves. Two books re-iced after thawing.

Vale did not scold. They pointed to a plaque:

CONFLICT IS WEATHER. REPAIR IS HEAT.

"Read the repair chapter together," Vale said. "Or lose access."

They sat on the cold floor, backs against warm stone, and read alternate paragraphs from a slim book titled *How to Come Back After Sharp Words*.

Eli read the apology lines. Noor read the listening lines.

Warmth returned slowly, honestly.

Not perfect. Not instant. But real.

Vale brought tea without comment. Other readers gave them space. The wing did not shame conflict — it named it weather and offered tools.

They read the repair chapter twice. The second time hurt less. The third time Eli laughed at a line about socks as

peace offerings and Noor laughed too, surprised.

Frost retreated from the re-iced books slowly. Vale helped them shelve the thawed volumes with ceremony — not triumph, gratitude.

"You may fight," Vale said. "You may not abandon each other in the cold you made."

Eli wrote that on his wrist. Noor wrote it in her planner.

On the way home through the main library, they walked closer than usual, not glued, just within reach.

The next morning they returned without being asked. Vale had left a new book on the threshold: *The Argument That Ended in Soup*.

They read it laughing and sniffing at once — a story about siblings who fought over chores until a neighbor taught them to cook together.

Eli read the kitchen scenes. Noor read the apology scenes. Ice melted into shapes like steam.

"Meta thaw," Eli said.

"Delicious meta," Noor agreed.

They made actual soup that night at home, trading tasks without keeping score. Their grandmother said the broth tasted like peace. They did not tell her about magic wings. They did not need to.

Chapter 8 — The Lantern of Shared Breath

Vale gave them a lantern that lit only when both twins spoke the same word at once.

They tried for an hour.

Warmth: no. Home: close. Sorry: almost. Together: yes.

The lantern flared gold.

With it, they thawed a shelf of community stories about neighbors sharing coats, tools, soup, and silence when silence was needed.

Eli said, "This wing is basically a feelings laboratory."

Noor said, "A useful one."

Keeper Vale smiled. "Winter is not punishment. It is pacing."

They used the lantern on harder books — community histories, letters from distant winters, a memoir about learning to hear after years of shouting.

Each thaw left dew on the shelves that smelled like paper and pine.

Eli taught the lantern game to a younger reader who struggled to sync with her brother. They said "listen" together on the fourth try. The lantern flared. The children gasped like it was magic.

"It is practice," Noor said. "Magic is what practice looks like from outside."

Vale added a fourth rule to their card: Return after sharp words.

The twins read it aloud together. The card warmed.

"Rule four was always there," Vale said. "You earned the ink."

Chapter 9 — The Last Frozen Book

One book remained fully iced: The Gatekeeper's Goodbye.

Vale admitted quietly, "That one is mine."

Noor and Eli understood. This was not a test of skill. It was a test of care.

They asked Vale to sit between them.

They read slowly, in turns, while Vale listened to their own story told back in warm voices.

The ice did not shatter. It softened, layer by layer, like spring arriving on a schedule only patience understands.

When the last page thawed, Vale wept without shame.

"Thank you," they said. "For not hurrying my ending into spring."

The book told Vale's story — years at the gate, readers helped, goodbyes postponed, loneliness thawed by voices not their own.

Noor read the sad pages. Eli read the brave pages. When Vale's hands shook, they did not take over. They waited.

The last page held one sentence: I am ready for the wing to have many keepers.

Vale signed it with a fingerprint that melted the final ice.

The twins received a secondary stamp: CARE COMPLETE.

"That is the highest rank here," Vale said. "Higher than speed. Higher than volume."

Eli cleared his throat. "Can we hug the keeper?"

Vale laughed and opened their cloak like wings.

Chapter 10 — The Gate Opens Wider

With Vale's book thawed, the Winter Gate widened.

Other readers entered — parents, children, elders, solo travelers — all instructed to read aloud, share hard pages, and respect thawing sentences.

Noor and Eli became junior guides, not bosses.

They taught newcomers the glove trick, the lantern word game, the rule of returning after sharp fights.

Eli discovered he liked teaching when he could make people laugh first.

Noor discovered she liked teaching when she could make people breathe first.

Together they were balanced.

They made a beginner path through the wing — gloves first, rule card second, easy thaw third, hard page last only if ready.

Eli led joke warm-ups: read the title like a pirate, like a chef, like a very serious frog. Laughter melted nervousness faster than shouting.

Noor led breathing warm-ups: in for four, out for six, read on the next line.

Parents thanked them. Solo travelers stayed longer than planned. One elder read a love letter from 1892 and cried without embarrassment.

The gate widened not in size but in permission — permission to go slow, to stumble, to return.

Vale watched from the alcove, retired but present, mending page scraps into new cloaks for future keepers.

Chapter 11 — Spring Appointment

On the last snow-night, Keeper Vale announced retirement from gatekeeping.

"The wing no longer needs one keeper," they said. "It needs many warm voices."

Noor and Eli were offered the role jointly.

They accepted on one condition: keep Tuesdays open for beginners.

Vale agreed and handed them a key shaped like a quotation mark.

"Use it wisely," Vale said. "And loudly enough."

Snow fell outside the labyrinth windows while inside the wing stayed cool but kind. The twins hung a Tuesday sign: BEGINNERS WELCOME — MISTAKES INCLUDED.

They tested the quotation-mark key on the door. It turned with a sound like a page corner unfolding.

"Joint keepership," Eli said, trying the title on like a coat.

"Joint responsibility," Noor added.

They agreed on shifts, on snack duty, on who handled the lantern when both were tired.

Vale left a final note: Do not confuse cold with cruelty. Winter protects. Warmth delivers.

Noor pinned it above the rule card. Eli drew a small sun beside it that looked suspiciously like a pancake.

Before the ceremony, they rehearsed their keeper vows aloud:

We will read slowly when stories are shy. We will return when we fight. We will make room for beginners. We will not confuse volume with care.

The wing listened. Frost on the dedication wall thinned to reveal older vows from keepers long gone — same promises, new handwriting.

Noor felt the weight of continuity. Eli felt the thrill of responsibility. Both felt ready enough, which was the only kind of ready Winter Gate accepted.

Maya, Natalia, and Alana attended as witnesses. SPARK recorded audio for the archive. The quotation-mark key warmed in their joined hands.

Chapter 12 — Voices That Stay Warm

Years later — though in labyrinth time, years can feel like seasons — Winter Gate Library remained a place where shy stories thawed safely.

Noor became a teacher of slow reading. Eli became a mapmaker of listening routes. Together they kept the gate open, even on busy days.

On the dedication wall, a line from their first week remained:

Enter with warm voice.

Beneath it, visitors added new lines:

Stay with the hard page. Return after sharp words. See the quiet child.

The frost never disappeared completely. It did not need to.

Cold still protected what was tender.

Warm voices still did the rest.

On the first Tuesday of their keepership, a new reader arrived — a boy who refused to speak above a mumble. Eli remembered the ice map. Noor remembered the marble.

They did not demand volume. They offered company.

By the end of the hour, the boy read one paragraph at regular voice. The wing thawed a whole shelf of adventure stories in response.

Noor and Eli high-fived quietly. Vale, watching from the alcove, nodded once.

Eli whispered to Noor, "We are doing it."

"We are keeping it," she whispered back.

Outside, snow continued. Inside, sentences warmed one voice at a time.

The Winter Gate breathed frost and welcome in the same breath — a reminder that some stories need cold first so they are not broken by hurry.

And warm voices, patiently returned, still did the rest.

THE END